building solid and constructive relationships with its neighbours had been spotty at best. The American intelligence assessment further noted:

Since independence in 1947, India's relentless and often heavy handed pursuit of leverage over its far weaker neighbors and its insistence on a benign hegemony over the subcontinent, in our view, have created a series of adversarial bilateral relationships and have poisoned the atmosphere for a regional approach to common problems. We believe that both Bhutan and Nepal continue to worry that Sikkim's fate may someday be their own. New Delhi remembers the secret US air facility at Peshawar and has publicly voiced its suspicion that the new US security relationship with Pakistan provides similar

privileges. India insists on dealing with each of its neighbors on a bilateral basis —a form of 'divide and rule.' This policy enables New Delhi to enjoy the benefits of its size and power without the risk of being chastised or outvoted at multilateral regional meetings. It is also meant to discourage the smaller states from working in concert against Indian interests, a tactic the Indians term encirclement.

The CIA also worried that increasing the USA arms supply to Pakistan may foment trouble in the region and in case of a war between India and Pakistan, the Soviets would support New Delhi. US intelligence officials believed that India would welcome the withdrawal of Pakistani support to Afghan resistance. But the Americans were in no mood to do so.

In December 1982, a group of R&AW operatives, facilitated by Mirza to set up safe houses and listening posts in two unidentified yet sensitive provinces, quietly entered Afghanistan. Later, two members of Parliament from the